

ARTILLERY (1939–45)

Field artillery continued to play an important role during World War II. While artillery manufacture was handled by commercial companies in Germany, in countries such as Britain, artillery was built by the state. A lot of British artillery tactical thinking was still based on ideas from World War I—centered around improving twists in rifling and fire controls—and this restricted the speedy development of new designs. While howitzers and mortars continued to be used, new threats spurred the development of antitank (see pp.232–33) and antiaircraft (see pp.234–35) guns.

► BRITISH 7.2IN BL HOWITZER MARK III ON US M8 CARRIAGE

Date 1940

Origin UK

Length (Excluding carriage)
45ft (13.71m)

Caliber 7.2in

Range more than 7 miles (11.26km)

This gun had originally been designed for a two-wheeled box trail carriage. It was found to be too powerful when using a full propellant charge and so was mounted on the more stable M8 gun carriage. The gun was introduced in 1943 and became the main heavy gun of the British Army.

► M1938 122MM HOWITZER

Date 1939

Origin Soviet Union

Length (Excluding carriage)
19¼ft (5.9m)

Caliber 122mm

Range 7½ miles (11.8km)

Also known as the M30, this field howitzer was a mainstay of the Red Army's artillery division. Maintained by a crew of eight, it could fire six rounds per minute.



FULL VIEW

◄ M1A1 PACK HOWITZER

Date 1940

Origin US

Length (Excluding carriage)
12ft (3.68m)

Caliber 75mm

Range 1½ miles (2.56km)

This lightweight howitzer was developed for use on rough terrain, where it could be broken down into separate pieces and carried by pack animals. It was also successfully assigned to US airborne forces.

Trail spades (here in traveling position) managed recoil and ensured that the gun remained stable while firing.